

**Comments received by Verra during the public comment period 13 May – 12 June 2024
for the validation and verification of the Asaga Amazonas REDD+, project ID 4452**

CCB Standards 3rd Edition

VCS 3rd Edition

Published 21 June 2024

Comment 1

Date: 05/06/2024

Sent by: Denis da Silva Pereira

Organization: Ministério Do Desenvolvimento Agrário E Agricultura Familiar, Instituto Nacional De Colonização E Reforma Agrária

Country: Brazil

Comment:

Prezado Senhor,

1. Cumprimentando-o, esta Superintendência do Incra no Amazonas, tomou conhecimento do Projeto "AsagaAmazonas REDD+", registrado no site da organização VERRA disponível em <https://registry.terra.org/app/projectDetail/VCS/4452>. A localização do Projeto está sobre terras da União, assentamento PAE Aripuanã-Guariba. Na página 28 do Projeto, menciona-se o Incra como um dos parceiros. Do exposto, solicita-se informar:

- a) Qual o documento fundiário de domínio da propriedade da terra que embasa o projeto? Favor anexar.
 - b) Houve algum contato de VERRA, do proponente ou desenvolvedor com o Incra ou qualquer organismo federal do Brasil para anuência ou ciência do Projeto? Favor anexar comprovação.
 - c) VERRA obteve a anuência ou ciência formal expressa de todos os parceiros citados na pag. 28/29 do Projeto?
 - d) VERRA conferiu a validade e integridade das informações quanto à titularidade ou domínio das terras do Projeto ID 4452? Favor apresentar documentos que comprovem a verificação.
2. Favor tomar com referência o prazo de resposta em até 10 dias corridos, a partir do qual esta Superintendência do Incra fará os encaminhamentos que julgar adequado, com o seu a resposta de V. Sra.
3. Sem mais, colocamo-nos à disposição para quaisquer esclarecimento também pelo Whatsapp Institucional (92) 99475-7606.

Comment 2

Date: 10/06/2024

Sent by: Not Available

Organization: Not Available

Country: Not Available

Comment: “Este projeto é crucial para o desenvolvimento, fortalecimento e gestão do território do PAE Aripuanã-Guariba. Dezenas de famílias vivem e zelam pela floresta que é fonte de renda e sustento através da coleta racional e planejada do óleo de copaíba. Cabe ainda ressaltar que o apoio para desenvolvimento sustentável requer investimentos e treinamentos, sendo assim com a aprovação deste projeto muitas pessoas serão impactadas positivamente e irão manter cada vez mais a floresta em pé.”

Comment 3

Date: 12/06/2024

Sent by: Not Available

Organization: Not Available

Country: Not Available

Comment:

“Asaga Amazonas REDD+

“2.1.14 Project start date”: please clarify how the “agreements with the involved local communities represented through the ASAGA association” are related to the reduction of emissions in the Project Area.

“3.1.2 Applicability of the Methodology”: it was not clear whether or not the project will carry out logging in the project scenario (the text seems to state yes, but the graph indicates no).

“Leak management areas”: describe how activities will be conducted to prevent leaks. The PD mentions the production of seedlings and plantings, but it is not clear how deforestation will be reduced.

“3.2.4 Net reductions and removals of GHG emissions”: in the PD and MR, a more detailed description of the calculations is recommended, so that any reader can reproduce them for checking.

In internal analysis, we noticed signs of overestimation of the baseline, which could be remedied through additional explanations about how the historical average deforestation rate and the model inputs were defined. These explanations will help reassure stakeholders about the rigor of the analysis and the accuracy of the projection.

The PD does not clearly indicate the similarity parameters between RR and PA required by VM0015, version 1.1 of December 2012. Therefore, it is not possible to verify whether the proportions of the analyzed classes are within the required limit. The Project Area consists of 461,095 hectares of the Aripuanã-Guariba PAE. Settlements are collectively owned public lands, belonging to the settlers, who have decision-making autonomy over them, although it is prudent to consult INCRA. To move forward with the project, the most important thing is to obtain the prior legitimate consent of the settlers and ensure that the settlement is regulated.

It is important that post-start date deforestation is presented on maps in documents, both for the Project Area and for the Leakage Belt. “3.2.4 Net reductions and removals of GHG emissions”: in the PD and

MR, a more detailed description of the calculations is recommended, so that any reader can reproduce them for checking.”

Comment 4

Date: 13/06/2024

Sent by: Not Available

Organization: Not Available

Country: Not Available

Comment:

Regarding the Project Summary (G1.2):

Lack of Clarity in Project Development: The details of the activities and implementation mechanisms of REDD+ in the Asaga Amazonas project are vague, superficial, and lack effective indicators. For example, item 2.1.5 Physical Parameters (G1.3) only describes the physical aspects of the project's "baseline" without detailing a protection program for the project area's ecosystem. The same comment applies to the "Project Area Map" (G1.4-7,G1.13,CM1.2,B1.2).

Lack of Crucial Information: There is a lack of crucial information about area selection, eligibility criteria, monitoring and evaluation mechanisms, and consultation and participation processes for local communities, which are summarized in the creation of a consultation protocol. Without this transparency, it is impossible to assess the effectiveness, real impacts, and adherence of the project to REDD+ principles and safeguards, which compromises the project's integrity.

Regarding 2.1.8 Stakeholder Identification (G1.5): Failure to Acknowledge Federal Ownership: The project does not clearly state that the area belongs to the Brazilian federal government or the concept of a federal settlement, which is in disagreement with the Safeguards. The claim that the project meets REDD+ safeguards is vague without any real indicators of existence. This is because Brazil already has existing regulations on the application of safeguards in REDD+ projects.

Vague Reference to Stakeholders: The project summarizes stakeholders by indicating "the presence of facilitating government institutions" without indicating which entities these would be and their level of participation during the process. The lack of clarity about implementation mechanisms and the lack of data raises concerns about how the rights of indigenous and traditional communities, biodiversity, and social rights will be protected. It is essential that the project presents a detailed plan for how the safeguards will be implemented and monitored, ensuring the active participation, free, prior, and informed consent of affected communities.

Lack of Proof of Land Ownership: The project does not prove ownership of the land. The proponents do not have the title to the property where the project is located. The project leads one to understand that the responsibility for the federal settlement lies with companies, NGOs, or private entities and induces a serious error, capable of generating civil liability. In Brazil, these areas are called federal settlements, a constitutional management obligation of the Federal Government. The project does not bring the mandatory information that the settlement is the responsibility of the federal government, removing any management by a private company, which, in doing so, violates federal regulations.

Regarding Access of Stakeholders to Project Documents (G3.1):



Missing REDD+ Safeguards Program: The project does not describe any REDD+ safeguards program, an essential point for evaluating the integrity of any project in partnership with local communities, especially when it comes to the CCB requirement.

Making documents available in PDF via email and printed copies does not guarantee real access for communities with reading difficulties. Translations into Portuguese, although necessary, should be accompanied by continuous oral explanations and in accessible language by qualified cultural mediators, instead.

The annual meetings described in the project are insufficient. Access to information is restricted to community leaders and reaches the rest of the population late, in addition to preventing active participation in decision-making. Regular meetings with a minimum frequency of every three months and simultaneous translation are the minimum and essential that is expected of a REDD+ project. of former police officers, as is the case with the REDDA company.

The community is not the real proponent, as it does not have access to the documents of the advance negotiation of the credits, with the investor, which is located in Dubai. In addition, the association does not have decision-making power over the project, as the proposing company does not allow access to the documents negotiated with buyers, restricting information to what is available on the Verra platform. The community does not know what the values are being traded and does not have the power to transfer these credits, as everything is concentrated in the company outside Brazil (Dubai).

The project was audited by the same company that approved the project, which generates distrust and risk of exclusion of marginalized groups. Clear, transparent criteria based on specific socio-environmental studies on the area should be disclosed and made available for public consultation, instead of a simple copy of generic data from the entire region

Non-detailed monitoring and evaluation mechanisms: The project makes it impossible to evaluate the project's effectiveness and identify failures or negative impacts. Monitoring methodologies should be detailed, public, and subject to independent review. It is verified that there is not even a monitoring program in the project.

Lack of effective communication channels: Contacts are restricted to interested proponents and hide or hinder communication between communities, government, and other stakeholders.** Diversified, accessible, impartial, and culturally appropriate channels should be implemented to ensure the free flow of information and the active participation of all those involved.

Territory management is not the responsibility of the proponents or the REDDA company. The statement is false, irregular, and irresponsible. The directly interested company should not assume public functions. Its role should be limited to the technical and financial support of a project, under the rigorous supervision of the Brazilian government, the real owner of the territory.

The lack of clarity in the responsibilities described in the project generates legal uncertainty and opens loopholes for the omission of duties by the company. The responsibilities of each actor must be clearly defined and formalized in public agreements.

Privatization of Public Goods: The proposing company, when dealing with political risks, omits the fact that no private company should benefit from the exploitation of federal public goods such as the Amazon forests without prior legal authorization. The project does not reveal that it has authorization from the federal government, describes facts and raises serious concerns about the usurpation of environmental services, amidst a national legislative discussion and anticipates the risk of commoditization of nature, going against the principles of REDD+ and sustainable development. The project can be completely

canceled as soon as the carbon market is approved in Brazil, generating serious damage to buyers and providers of environmental services, such as the local community itself.

Biodiversity Risks: The project points to the rich biodiversity of the region, including endemic species and the Sucunduri Dome, which is threatened by the activities planned in the project, such as logging, infrastructure construction, and energy generation. However, the project does not present any clear or sufficient effective measures to mitigate these impacts, in order to guarantee the protection of biodiversity in the long term. The identification of this biodiversity does not reveal any effectiveness or additionality of the project.

Pressures on Natural Resources: The region already faces a high rate of deforestation and forest fires, in addition to the pressure from agricultural expansion, mining, and construction of hydroelectric power plants. The REDD+ project as described, without the guarantees required by any proponent, generates the risk of intensifying these pressures and conflicts between agents, leading to environmental degradation, social conflicts and human rights violations.

Lack of Tangible Benefits: The activities proposed by the project, such as income generation and access to clean energy, are merely descriptive and the data is from third parties, such as NGOs and government agencies, which already work in the region without the need to implement a REDD+ project. In addition, the number of jobs does not even exist, let alone the details about the type of work. This absence of data reveals that there is only a promise to the local residents and that the project's activities do not guarantee concrete and lasting benefits for the local communities. It is crucial that the project presents a detailed plan on how these benefits will be managed, distributed and monitored, ensuring the participation of the communities in the definition and implementation of the actions.

The Asaga Amazonas REDD+ Project is located in the same region as the "EVERGREEN REDD+ PROJECT (Project ID 2539), which was targeted by the Brazilian federal police and is currently suspended by VERRA on suspicion of fraud. In its current form, the project presents the same serious flaws in terms of transparency, accountability, environmental protection and social benefits.

It is essential that the project be paralyzed by the certifier, demanding the correction of irregularities, if it intends to maintain the integrity of its REDD+ system. There must be strong accountability of the contracted audits, which currently allow fragile projects like this to pass.

REDD+ projects must act comprehensively to meet the most basic principles of the REDD+ mechanism, with total transparency, active participation of local communities and not just concentrated on leaders, which violates all robust monitoring and evaluation mechanisms. Without these significant changes, other projects run the risk of having to cover up such irregularities arising from these fragile projects, in addition to deepening the socio-environmental problems of the region and violating the rights of traditional populations.

Comment 5

Date: 20/05/2024

Sent by: Not Available

Organization: Not Available

Country: Not Available

Comment: "I'd like to understand how the definition of the project area was established and how it is currently being developed. According to MapBiomass and PRODES, there are deforestation alerts within the project area. I would like to get a clearer understanding of how the project area is being defined."

Comment 6

Date: 20/05/2024

Sent by: Not Available

Organization: Not Available

Country: Not Available

Comment: "Another relevant point is that there are IBAMA embargoes in the area. As I understand it, an embargo prohibits the continuation of any economic activity in the area. Since carbon is a commodity like any other, what is IBAMA's position on the continuation of carbon generation activities?"

Comment 7

Date: 20/05/2024

Sent by: Not Available

Organization: Not Available

Country: Not Available

Comment: "What is REDDA's relationship with Kevin Tremain?"

Verra has suspended the Pacajai / ADPML Portel-Pará REDD project. The project developer faces a legal case over land grabbing. Local communities say they have not received benefits from the project (substack.com).

https://youtu.be/o9X_W4z-2kQ

Comment 8

Date: 20/05/2024

Sent by: Not Available

Organization: Not Available

Country: Not Available

Comment: "In view of the proximity of this project to other carbon projects, Would I like to clarify whether the project area takes into account the leakage areas of these other projects neighboring ASAGA AMAZONAS REDD?"

Comment 9

Date: 21/05/2024

Sent by: Not Available

Organization: Not Available

Country: Not Available

Comment: "What is the legitimacy of ASAGA to represent all settlers? How was this legitimacy conducted? How was the association building process carried out, what is the purpose of the social statute, is it included with carbon benefits, how will the distribution of carbon rights be, will it be through the association or directly to the members?"
